EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Has Mashiah Already Come? Fifteen Proofs He Hasn't

Given Monday 21 July 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 8:8-9

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 8 (The Final Redemption), Chapters 8 and 9

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 21 July 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

The Last Shiur of the Term

The final class of the summer term, completing Essay 8. After the break, from early September in Elul, comes **Essay 9 on Olam HaBa**, which should take a couple of months, and then **Essay 10**, which is part of the book but "a whole different kind of approach. It's less philosophical, it's more just musar, ethical encouragement," after Sukkot. The aim is to finish the whole sefer by the end of 2025.

Recap: Essay 8 So Far

- **Chapters 1 to 4:** the purpose of the redemption, to save us from exile, bring us together into Eretz Yisrael and be Hashem's chosen people; and **two times** for it: the fixed **קץ**, or any time we merit it by improving our ways. Saadia worked out what he believed was the *ketz*, but "he wasn't precise with that." He predicted 963, "so we're already a thousand years over his prediction."
- **Chapters 5 and 6:** the redemption comes through a person, **Mashiach**. It will certainly be **Mashiach ben David**, perhaps preceded by **Mashiach ben Yosef** if we have to wait for the *ketz*. Ben Yosef gathers some of the people, has early success, and is killed; many give up hope; there is the war of **Gog uMagog**; then ben David. If we return of our own accord, none of that is needed. Saadia gathered the prophecies into a timeline. "Whether it's going to happen exactly as he predicts, we'll wait to see. As the Rambam said, when it happens we'll see exactly how it happens." But almost everyone agrees there will be a redemption, through a person called Mashiach.
- **Chapters 7 to 9:** refutations of those who say the redemption is **not** coming, not because the prophecies are false, but for two reasons:
- **The prophecies were conditional**, and we sinned and lost them. Chapter 7 gave **five refutations**: unlike Moshe's promises in the Torah, the consolations in Yeshayahu, Yirmiyahu and Yechezkel carry no conditions.
- **They were already fulfilled** in the Second Temple period. That is tonight's **Chapter 8**.
- **Chapter 9:** the Christian claim that Mashiach already came, in Jesus.

Chapter 8: Fifteen Proofs

וכיון שחקרתי יסוד בנינם, אשיבה עליהם אחר כן בחמשה עשר שער: חמשה מהם מן הכתוב, וחמשה מן ההגדה, וחמשה ממה שישיגהו החוש

Saadia answers the claim that the prophecies were fulfilled in the Second Temple with **fifteen proofs**:

- **five from the verses** themselves, compared with what Scripture records of the Second Temple;
- **five from tradition and history**: things we have never been told happened;
- **five from what we can see** with our own senses.

"This is very timely," the Rabbi noted: some of these prophecies are in the **Shiva d'Nechemta**, the seven haftarot of consolation after Tishah b'Av. "And Saadia takes a very literal approach to many of these things."

Five from the Verses

1. Every Jew will be gathered in

וקבצתים מן הארצות, והביאותים אל אדמתם (Yechezkel 34:13)

Saadia reads the prophecy as **all** of Israel, with no one left in exile. But in the Second Temple period only **42,360** returned: **כל הקהל כאחד ארבע רבוא אלפים שלש מאות וששים** (Nechemiah 7:66).

"Okay, that's not decisive," the Rabbi said, because "I will gather them" might mean most of them. But it is a fact that not everyone came back: there are communities that trace themselves to the First Temple exile, who stayed on in Iraq, Persia and Iran. For Saadia, the final redemption means everyone. "No one's going to be forgotten about."

2. From the islands

Yeshayahu says we will be gathered **from the islands of the sea**. The first exile was only to Bavel and Persia, "Iraq and Iran," never to islands, so the return from it cannot be this prophecy. "Whereas now, of course, at least in England, we're living on an island, and many Jews across the world are living on islands."

3. The nations will build the walls

ובנו בני נכר חמתיך (Yeshayahu 60:10)

In the Second Temple period, far from helping, the nations **stopped us building**, for a pause of about eighteen or nineteen years, and the walls were built under threat:

באחת ידו עשה במלאכה, ואחת מחזקת השלח (Nechemiah 4:11)

One hand on the bricks, the other on a weapon. Again, "not a decisive proof," since Koresh did help, and the prophecy might mean that some nations would lend their authority to the building.

4. The gates always open

ופתחו שעריך תמיד, יומם ולילה לא יסגרו (Yeshayahu 60:11)

Yerushalayim will be so secure that its gates never close. But in the Second Temple period they **closed the gates** before sunset and opened them only late in the day: **לא יפתחו שערי ירושלם עד חם השמש** (Nechemiah 7:3). So that prophecy must be about the third Temple.

5. All nations will serve us

כי הגוי והממלכה אשר לא יעבדוך יאבדו (Yeshayahu 60:12)

In the Second Temple period we ourselves were under foreign rule: **הנה אנחנו היום עבדים, והארץ אשר נתתה לאבתינו** (Nechemiah 9:36).

"Although many great things happened in the time of the Second Temple, these five things didn't happen." If they have not happened, they must still happen.

Five from Tradition and History

"We have never been told these things happened." Saadia again reads them literally.

6. Seven years of fuel from Gog's weapons

ויצאו ישבי ערי ישראל ובערו והשיקו בנשק ומגן וצנה, בקשת ובחצים ובמקל יד וברמח, ובערו בהם אש שבע שנים (Yechezkel 39:9)

After the war of Gog, the leftover weapons will serve as fuel for seven years. We are never told this happened. "Are we going to use the weapons for fuel for seven years? We'll see, I suppose. Perhaps we've moved on, we don't need these things anymore."

7. The rivers split

The river of Egypt will be dried up in one place and the **Perat**, the Euphrates, split into **seven** streams: **והחרים ה׳ את לשון ים מצרים... והכהו לשבעה נחלים** (Yeshayahu 11:15). It never happened.

8. The Mount of Olives split

ונבקע הר הזיתים מחציו מזרחה וימה גיא גדולה מאד (Zechariah 14:4)

The Mount of Olives will split into a northern half and a southern half with a great valley between. We do not know that this ever happened.

9. The Temple built to Yechezkel's plan

Yechezkel gives the form of the House from beginning to end. **The Second Temple was not built according to those instructions**, so his prophecy must be about the third.

10. The river from the Temple

והנה מים יצאים מתחת מפתן הבית (Yechezkel 47:1)

A great river will flow out from the Mikdash, with fruit trees on both banks whose fruit never fails, **for food and for healing**:

ועל הנחל יעלה על שפתו מזה ומזה כל עץ מאכל... והיה פריו למאכל ועלהו לתרופה (Yechezkel 47:12)

"It's very easy to explain away many of these prophecies as being not literal, but metaphoric. But Saadia takes them all very literally."

Five We Can See for Ourselves

"These are very strong proofs."

11. All humanity will know God is One

ביום ההוא יהיה ה׳ אחד ושמו אחד (Zechariah 14:9)

"We say this every day in Aleinu." Yet we still see people who deny God and do not recognise His unity.

12. No more taxes to other nations

נשבע ה׳ בימינו ובזרוע עזו, אם אתן את דגנך עוד מאכל לאיביך (Yeshayahu 62:8)

Hashem swore that we would never again give our produce to others. Yet Jews everywhere still pay taxes to the countries they live in.

13. No more war

וכתתו חרבותם לאתים... לא ישא גוי אל גוי חרב (Yeshayahu 2:4)

"This is a famous prophecy." Yet "we have nuclear weapons now. Every nation is trying to develop the best weapons."

14. Wolf and lamb

וגר זאב עם כבש (Yeshayahu 11:6)

The wolf will graze with the lamb, the lion will eat straw like cattle, and a nursing child will play by a snake's hole. But the lion still devours, the wolf still devours and the snake still bites.

This is the one prophecy Saadia allows might be read **metaphorically**: perhaps it only means that bad people and good people will no longer harm each other. **Even so, it has not happened.** There is no less violence, robbery and oppression of the weak today than before. "Either way you look at this prophecy, it hasn't happened, so it must happen in the future."

15. Sedom restored

ושבתי את שביתהן, את שבות סדם ובנותיה... תשבן לקדמתן (Yechezkel 16:53, 55)

Sedom will return to its original state. What was that? Before the destruction, its waters were sweet:

וישא לוט את עיניו וירא את כל ככר הירדן כי כלה משקה... כגן ה׳ כארץ מצרים (Bereishit 13:10)

That is why Lot chose it when he parted from Avraham. Today, "when you're driving down from Yerushalayim past the Yam HaMelach," it is all dry and salty.

Saadia's conclusion

ואלה הענינים כולם מורים ראיה גמורה על שהנחמות אלו לא היו עדיין

All fifteen together are a complete proof that **these consolations have not yet come**. The prophets promised them, so they must still come, in the final redemption. Anyone who says the redemption will not come because it already happened must explain these fifteen promises. "It cannot be Mashiach has come already."

The Rambam, the Rabbi added, did not go into all of this. "The Rambam just said, wait and see." Saadia takes the words of the prophets very literally and awaits them.

A question: was Saadia also answering the Christians?

A participant suggested that Saadia, living among people who strongly believed their Mashiach had already come, was helping Jews to deal with that. "That's precisely correct." Chapter 7 began with "people

who call themselves Jews," most likely the Karaites. But the very first sentence of Chapter 9 says these same fifteen proofs answer the Christians too.

Chapter 9: Against the Christian Claim

וכל אשר השיבונו על אלה, היא תשובת הנוצרים

None of the fifteen prophecies came true in the time of Jesus either, so he cannot have been Mashiach.

A puzzle about the dates

Saadia reports that the Christians placed Jesus **138 years before the destruction of the Second Temple** (some texts have a slightly different number). With the destruction in 70 CE, that would put him around 68 BCE, which does not match the usual dating. One suggestion is that in Saadia's time some held he was born then and that the count of the era was from his crucifixion. "It does seem there was an opinion held at the time" of a date sixty or seventy years earlier than we understand today. The Rabbi said he had not researched what the Christian view was a thousand years ago.

The proof from the seventy weeks

The Christians also bring a specific proof from **Daniel 9**, the "seventy weeks." Everyone, including us, agrees these are weeks of **years**: 70 times 7, **490 years**. At the end, the verse says:

ואחרי השבעים ששים ושנים יכרת משיח ואין לו (Daniel 9:26)

"Mashiach will be cut off." They read this as Jesus being crucified: so Mashiach came, was killed, and it is all over.

Saadia's reading of the 490 years: from the exile to the building of the Second Temple and through its existence. Of them, **434** were the time of the House, which stood 420 years, since there was an interruption early in the building (**ושבעים ששים ושנים תשוב ונבנתה רחוב וחרוץ ובצוק העתים**), as recorded at the start of Ezra. The last "week" is a time of war, trouble and broken covenant. The 490 years **combine good and bad**, as someone might say, "I spent fifty days at a wedding, in sickness and in drunkenness": a single total covering different kinds of time.

"Cut off" is not Jesus: four answers

1. **"Mashiach" does not mean a specific person.** "People think Mashiach is a specific kind of person. His name is Mr Mashiach." It simply means **anointed**, from the root **משח**, as in **הכהן המשיח** in Shemot, Vayikra and Tzav. The verse means **every anointed Kohen will be cut off**: with the destruction, the line of Kohanim Gedolim came to an end.
2. **The word *yikaret* is used only for a just death. כל אכל חלב... ונכרתה** (Vayikra 7:25): *karet* is the punishment for one who deserves it. But according to the Christians, Jesus was killed **unjustly**. So the verse would not use that word of him.
3. **It is tied to the destruction of the Temple.** The cutting off happens together with the destruction. Even by today's dates, Jesus died around 30 or 33 CE, decades before 70.
4. **The time span does not work.** From Daniel's vision to Jesus's death was only about 245 years, not 490. So, says Saadia, they invented a longer Persian period, claiming **seventeen Persian kings** over hundreds of years. He answers from Daniel that there were only **four**. "Honestly, I struggled to understand it completely."

Beyond this proof

Saadia closes by noting that, aside from these answers, Christianity holds that **the Torah has been abrogated**, against our belief that it never changes (Essay 3), and holds **the Trinity**, against the unity of God (Essay 2), and other things he will not bring in this book.

Summary

1. **Chapter 7 (last week):** the consolations are **unconditional**.
2. **Chapter 8:** the consolations **were not fulfilled** in the Second Temple period, by fifteen proofs:
3. **From the verses:** all Jews gathered in; from the islands; nations building the walls; gates always open; nations serving us.
4. **From history:** seven years of fuel from Gog's weapons; the rivers split; the Mount of Olives split; the Temple to Yechezkel's plan; the river and healing trees from the Temple.
5. **From what we see:** all humanity knowing God is One; no taxes to other nations; no more war; wolf and lamb (literal or metaphorical, neither has happened); Sedom restored.
6. **Chapter 9:** the same proofs answer the Christians. **"יכרת משיח"** means every anointed Kohen, not one man; *karet* means a just death; it belongs with the destruction of the Temple; and the 490 years do not fit.
7. **Essay 8 as a whole:** the purpose, timing and miracles of the redemption, and the refutation of those who say it already happened.

Coming Up

A break until **Monday 1 September**, when Essay 9, on **Olam HaBa**, begins: in Saadia's framework, "a whole new world," whereas resurrection and redemption happen in this world. Essay 9 in September and October, Essay 10 in November and December. "This whole book we began in January a year and a half ago." Over the holidays, the Rabbi suggested going back over what has been learned: the unity of God, prophecy, the soul, resurrection, and now Mashiach.

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